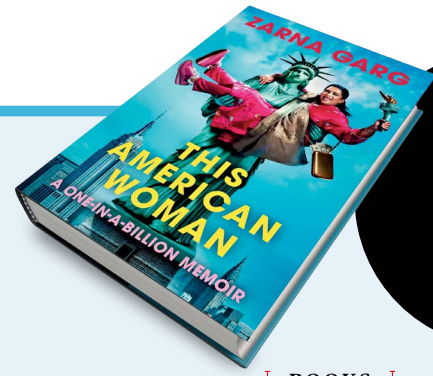
like what I'm doing, I would much rather not do anything and focus on something else. For me, there are always other things to do as opposed to working for the sake of working."

Khan points to her memoir *The Perils of Being Moderately Famous*, which was published in 2017, which she says she started writing just to find something to do. In the years since, the actor has written another children's book, turned it into an audiobook, and is currently working on a podcast along with getting in the thick of producing projects with her actor-director husband Kunal Kemmu.

Even her decision to make her digital debut with two web-series in 2022—*Hush Hush* and *Kaun Banegi Shikharwati*—stemmed from the fact that motherhood didn't seem to demand her single-minded focus now that her daughter was growing up. "I understand that not everyone might have this luxury but at this point in my life, I feel fortunate that I get to work only out of passion and out of what excites me." ■

**–Poulomi Das**




**THIS AMERICAN WOMAN:** A One-In-A-Billion Memoir
*By Zarna Garg*
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BOOKS

# COMIC BELIEF

Indian-American comedian **Zarna Garg** on making her acting debut in the new Hollywood film *A Nice Indian Boy* and writing her memoir

Comedian and podcaster Zarna Garg had a moment of self-doubt when director Roshan Sethi offered her a role in the queer, interracial romcom *A Nice Indian Boy*. After all, she had never acted on screen before. "He then told me not to worry. This was the role of a mother who had to be disappointed in her husband and kids. I immediately knew I could do this better than anybody else. Sit down, Meryl Streep because I've got this," says Garg in her trademark deadpan style.

Based on a play by Madhuri Shekar, *A Nice Indian Boy* is the story of an Indian boy who brings his white American fiancé to meet his desi parents. This ode to *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* also stars Karan Soni and Jonathan Groff. Garg describes her character Megha Gavaskar, mother to Soni's Naveen, as an "overbearing desi mother".



"Overbearing in the American context because there, parents are expected to be hands-off while any Indian mother will see her and immediately recognise herself in the character," adds the 50-year-old. The character is an extension of Garg's comedic persona, one that's rooted in the quirks of being an Indian mother living the American life.

Garg's ascent to fame after winning Kevin Hart's 2021 comedy competition, *Lyft Comics*, has been fast and furious. She has performed at historic venues like the Kennedy Center, had a stand-up special on Prime Video and opened for

**Garg's ascent to fame after winning Kevin Hart's 2021 comedy contest, *Lyft Comics*, has been fast and furious**

Tina Fey and Amy Poehler's *Restless Leg Tour*. But she has mostly worked alone and once Garg landed on the sets of *A Nice Indian Boy*, she realised just how different movie-making is. "It was a revelation just how collaborative the process is. I am very grateful to have worked with not just people I like but also trust." In the predominantly South Asian cast and crew, Groff—whose credits include voicing Kristoff in the animated musical *Frozen* and playing a serial-killer profiler in *Mindhunter*—fit right in. "On the first day when all of us met for the first time, he very honestly said 'I don't know much about your culture' and by the time filming ended, he was almost Indian."

Being a consummate multi-tasker means that Garg also has a memoir—*This American Woman*—releasing at the end of April. The book chronicles her life from moving to the US as a teenager after the death of her mother to the wildly unexpected career in show business. "I am often asked, specially by women of my age, about how I got here. And, very often I can see that they feel stuck and don't know what to do, having spent decades bearing and raising children. So, I thought why not answer this in a book." This became such a passion project that Garg put other projects on hold to tell this story. "At a time when the whole world looks like it's on fire...if I can offer hope to somebody and make them believe in themselves, then I feel like I owe it to the universe because the universe has been so kind to me." Later this year, her second comedy special *Practical People Win* will drop on JioHotstar. She also has a sitcom based on her comedic material and themes, co-produced by Mindy Kaling and Kevin Hart, in the works. ■

**–Karishma Upadhyay**